



FACTBOX

Number of players

206

Number of rounds

8

Prize money

\$2,000,000

(Winner - \$120,000)

Candidates spots at stake

3

In the limelight: Divya Deshmukh was given a wild card for this tournament. MICHAL WALUSZA / FIDE

Divya. She was given a wild card by FIDE, and this will be her first event in India after her stunning triumph at the Women's World Cup in Georgia in July.

This is her second major event in the open section, after she skipped the women's section of the Grand Swiss tournament and chose to play in the open event at Samarkand, Uzbekistan.

She did well too, with a Grandmaster-norm-level performance. But she didn't need that norm, as the World Cup had already given her the Grandmaster title directly.

The teenager from Nagpur — easily one of the most exciting young talents in women's chess — should gain from her experience in Goa, though nobody expects her to set the tournament on fire. With an Elo

rating of 2498, she is seeded 150th in a field of 206.

Anish Giri, fresh from his victory at the Grand Swiss, is the highest-seeded non-Indian. Despite his Indian-sounding name, he is Dutch with partial Nepalese lineage. He is seeded fourth and will be hoping to reproduce his form from Uzbekistan.

German Vincent Keymer and American Wesley So, seeded fifth and sixth respectively, are also among the contenders for the top prizes. There is a long list of other big stars, including Nodirbek Abdusattorov (Uzbekistan), Maxime Vachier-Lagrave (France), Wei Yi (China), Ian Nepomniachtchi (Russia) and Levon Aronian (USA).

With the World Cup, big-time chess returns to India after three years. The last major event the country hosted was the Chess Olympiad at Mamallapuram, near Chennai, in 2022. It was a roaring success — very well organised, with thousands queueing up to watch the

players in action after buying tickets. And the Indian fans had plenty to cheer about too, as the host nation won the bronze medal in both the open and women's sections.

Chennai had also hosted the 2013 World Championship between Viswanathan Anand and Carlsen.

That ended in disappointment for Anand's hometown as he lost his crown to his young challenger.

Back in 2000 in New Delhi, Anand had qualified for the World Championship final, which he went on to win in Tehran, the first of his five World titles.

As a mentor, he has played his part in shaping the golden generation of Indian chess.

This World Cup is not just an opportunity to underline India's dominance in world chess — the country holds the Olympiad title in both men's and women's categories — but also to once again play an excellent host, as FIDE now sees the country as an important destination for global events.